

CDN Incident Alert: 0048. TLP: CLEAR**Date****Title**

DE The Achilles' Heel of EU Media Sanctions: Reassessing RT Deutsch access ahead of Germany's 2025 Federal Election

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Summary

- The content of RT Deutsch, which is restricted in the EU, is appearing on mirror sites that remain accessible through Germany's four largest Internet Service Providers (ISPs), highlighting enforcement gaps.

- Impact: Even though EU sanctions from 2022 have reduced RT Deutsch' reach, user engagement on mirror sites sometimes outperforms the original domain's pre-sanction reach in terms of retention. The continued accessibility of RT mirror websites suggests that the spread of Russian state media remains possible despite efforts to restrict it.

- Recommendations: Monitoring and sanctioning RT mirror sites, alternative domains and traffic-redireciting platforms linked to the Kremlin (regulators); Restricting monetisation for RT mirror pages or redirecting traffic (regulators); Enhancing monitoring efforts by cooperation and intelligence-sharing to enhance enforcement (German ISPs); Banning RT domains and related alternative sites (search engines and social media platforms)

Incident

RT Deutsch mirror sites and pro-Kremlin actors have been spreading content from the sanctioned outlet through 20 mirror domains and 11 subdomains, circumventing EU sanctions. Many of these domains (17 of the 31 mirror domains) remain accessible via Germany's largest ISPs, with the fourth largest ISP failing to block any of them. Despite sanctions, these mirror sites continue to attract high user engagement, with over 90% of traffic originating from Germany. This suggests that pro-Kremlin actors are successfully bypassing restrictions through VPNs and DNS changes, ensuring continued access to Russian state media content. The persistence of these mirror sites raises concerns about the effectiveness of EU sanctions and their potential impact ahead of Germany's 2025 federal elections.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Criticising European foreign policy; lamenting degradation of the West; promoting alternate geopolitical alliance

Sub-narratives: German government is failing its citizens by supporting Ukraine over domestic issues; EVs are unreliable and prone to explosions and accidents

Impact

Reach: RT mirrors available via the three ISPs with the most users in Germany averaged 45,317 unique organic visitors in December 2024; the three most visited among the websites ranged between 102,100 and 213,900 unique organic visitors in the same month.

Key Objectives and Behaviours

Objective: T0002 Facilitate state propaganda

Objective: T0076 Distort

T0084 Reuse existing content

T0098.002: Leverage Existing Inauthentic News Sites

T0121.001: Bypass Content Blocking

T0149.001: Domain Asset

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Coordination with Alliance for Securing Democracy to deconflict investigations; [report published](#); circulated with relevant external stakeholders from media, government, civil society via email

Recommendations:

- European regulators should actively track websites that share RT content to refine their policy responses against state-controlled information manipulation. This includes monitoring alternative RT domains, mirror sites, copy-paste platforms, and those redirecting traffic to RT. If these sites are linked to the Kremlin, they should face sanctions similar to those imposed on official RT domains, particularly when they replicate the same content under different domain names.

- Monetisation for websites featuring RT content or redirecting traffic to its domains should be restricted as part of broader regulatory measures, as ad tech companies can play a key role in implementing these restrictions.
- German ISPs should enhance their monitoring efforts to detect and block RT Deutsch mirror domains and subdomains effectively in accordance with EU sanctions. In doing so, they should foster cooperation and intelligence-sharing (e.g., common blacklists) among ISPs to ensure comprehensive enforcement across all providers.
- Search engines should step up their efforts to exclude both official RT domains and related alternative sites from search results. Likewise, social media platforms must fully enforce the ban. This is especially relevant for X, which seems to limit access to RT's official domains based on user-reported location rather than IP addresses or other geolocation signals.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
Link	RT Deutsch, Election, Sanctions.	Upon request.	Pablo Maristany de las Casas & Kevin D. Reyes, ISD.	Website	